

Bob Ingram

'As I Was Saying ...'

Soft Shoe Man

WHEN DAVE GARCIA assumed the managership of the Sun Kings in 1964, one of the first announcements about his policies was about his players: "I'll treat them nice as long as they treat me nice."

It gave me the impression that the man who succeeded the easy-going George Genovese was going to be a tough disciplinarian. But Dave was not that type. He was a kind and gentle man with the players as he was with everyone on the outside. "Call me anytime, day or night," he said. "If you wake me up, I can go back to sleep."

His rapport with the players was good with one exception. He had a young left hander in Nick DeMatteis who had a fine arm. In fact, DeMatteis pitched a no-hit game against Tulsa.

But the southpaw hurler was over-weight and Dave nagged him during the season about shedding some surplus poundage.

Just before the playoffs that year, Nick exploded about something or other, threw various parts of his uniform all around the dressing room, walked out and vowed he wasn't coming back. Garcia just as steadfastly vowed that he wasn't going to DeMatteis and ask him to come back although the pitcher was needed in the playoffs. Andy Cohen, who was coach of the Kings, went to the hot-tempered pitcher, talked some sense into him and influenced him to apologize for his action. DeMatteis was reinstated and pitched in the playoffs.

He Showed Up

GARCIA HAD a hassle with an Amarillo player during a game at Dudley Field. It came close to fisticuffs. It could have been a bad match-up. A manager in his 40s against a much bigger and younger adversary.

"I'll see you right here at home plate after the game," the Amarillo player told Garcia.

The second the game was over, Dave headed for home plate to meet his challenger. It promised to be a high-noon affair. But the Amarillo man headed for his team's dressing room and never turned around.

"These players are all alike when it comes to fighting," said Dave in his post-game commentary.

Some Made It

A WHOLE CHAPTER could be written on "whatever happened to them?" Meaning quite a number of the players who played for Garcia here vanished with the wind. Players like Jack Blehm, Dennis Dittman, Ed Feldman, "Diablo" Montoya, (with a nickname like that, he should be playing for El Paso Diablos this year), Dave Turnbull, Bruce Von Hoff, Darrell Weber and others. Most of those players fell by the wayside.

But there were some "name" players too who are still remembered and some who've made their way into the big time. Tito Fuentes played second base for the Sun Kings. He had some problems afield and at bat. But Garcia predicted then that "he'll be the next second baseman of the San Francisco Giants." The El Paso manager was just slightly wrong. It took Fuentes a few years to make it with the big club but he finally has.

Arlo Engel, the man who Genovese liked to describe as having Ruthian power, may have had his last good year in baseball. He hit 25 homers and batted .305.

"The Moose" (Larry) Stubing had one of his big years in baseball, hitting .316 and powering the ball over the fences of the league 35 times.

Paul Doyle, a lefty who had that big move to first, was one of the Kings' best hurlers. Garcia recommended him as a big leaguer for sure.

And there was little Cesar Gutierrez who played some at short and later was a one-year sensation with the Detroit Tigers.

There were others who made it to the "big." But as already mentioned, a good many were never heard from again.

That was to be expected. What was hardly expected was to have Dave Garcia returning to El Paso as manager. The Diablos couldn't have gotten a nicer or more capable man.